

Chapter XII

The Recital



HE maliciousness of the cardinal did not leave much for the ambassador to say; nevertheless, the word 'restoration' had struck the king, who, addressing the comte, upon whom his eyes had been fixed since his entrance,—'Monsieur,' said he, 'will you have the kindness to give us some details concerning the affairs of England. You come from that country, you are a Frenchman, and the orders which I see glittering upon your person announce you to be a man of merit as well as a man of quality.'

'Monsieur,' said the cardinal, turning towards the queen-mother, 'is an ancient servant of your majesty's, Monsieur le Comte de la Fère.'

Anne of Austria was as oblivious as a queen whose life had been mingled with fine and stormy days. She looked at Mazarin, whose evil smile promised her something disagreeable; then she solicited from Athos, by another look, an explanation.

'Monsieur,' continued the cardinal, 'was a Tréville musketeer, in the service of the late king. Monsieur is well acquainted with England, whither he has made several voyages at various periods, he is a subject of the highest merit.'

These words made allusion to all the memories which Anne of Austria trembled to evoke. England, that was her hatred of Richelieu and her love for Buckingham; a Tréville musketeer, that was the whole Odyssey of the triumphs which had made the heart of the young woman throb, and of the dangers which had been so near overturning the throne of the young queen. These words had much power, for they rendered mute and attentive all the royal personages, who, with very various sentiments, set

about recomposing at the same time the mysteries which the young had not seen, and which the old had believed to be forever effaced.

'Speak, monsieur,' said Louis XIV, the first to escape from troubles, suspicions, and remembrances.

'Yes, speak,' added Mazarin, to whom the little malicious thrust directed against Anne of Austria had restored energy and gayety.

'Sire,' said the comte, 'a sort of miracle has changed the whole destiny of Charles II. That which men, till that time, had been unable to do, God resolved to accomplish.'

Mazarin coughed while tossing about in his bed.

'King Charles II,' continued Athos, 'left the Hague neither as a fugitive nor a conqueror, but as an absolute king, who, after a distant voyage from his kingdom, returns amidst universal benedictions.'

'A great miracle, indeed,' said Mazarin; 'for, if the news was true, King Charles II, who has just returned amidst benedictions, went away amidst musket-shots.'

The king remained impassible. Philip, younger and more frivolous, could not repress a smile, which flattered Mazarin as an applause of his pleasantry.

'It is plain,' said the king, 'there is a miracle; but God, who does so much for kings, monsieur le comte, nevertheless employs the hand of man to bring about the triumph of His designs. To what men does Charles II principally owe his re-establishment?'

'Why,' interrupted Mazarin, without any regard for the king's pride—'does not your majesty know that it is to M. Monk?'

'I ought to know it,' replied Louis XIV, resolutely; 'and yet I ask my lord ambassador, the causes of the change in this General Monk?'

'And your majesty touches precisely the question,' replied Athos, 'for without the miracle of which I have had the honour to speak, General Monk would probably have remained an implacable enemy of Charles II. God willed that a strange, bold, and ingenious idea should enter into the mind of a certain man, whilst a devoted and courageous idea took possession of the mind of another man. The combinations of these two ideas brought about such a change in the position of M. Monk, that, from an inveterate enemy, he became a friend to the deposed king.'

'Some fifty thousand crowns; yes, monseigneur,' replied the Comte de Guiche, rising. 'Must I give up my place to your eminence, or shall I continue?'

'Give up! give up! you are mad. You would lose all you have won.'

Peste!

'My lord!' said the Prince de Condé, bowing.

'Good-evening, monsieur le prince,' said the minister, in a careless tone; 'it is very kind of you to visit an old sick friend.'

'A friend!' murmured the Comte de la Fère, at witnessing with stupor this monstrous alliance of words;—'friends! when the parties are Condé and Mazarin!'

Mazarin seemed to divine the thoughts of the Frondeur, for he smiled upon him with triumph, and immediately,—'Sire,' said he to the king, 'I have the honour of presenting to your majesty, Monsieur le Comte de la Fère, ambassador from his Britannic majesty. An affair of state, gentlemen,' added he, waving his hand to all who filled the chamber, and who, the Prince de Condé at their head, all disappeared at the simple gesture. Raoul, after a last look cast at the comte, followed M. de Condé. Philip of Anjou and the queen appeared to be consulting about departing.

'A family affair,' said Mazarin, suddenly, detaining them in their seats.

'This gentleman is the bearer of a letter in which King Charles II, completely restored to his throne, demands an alliance between Monsieur, the brother of the king, and Mademoiselle Henrietta, grand-daughter of Henry IV. Will you remit your letter of credit to the king, monsieur le comte?'

Athos remained for a minute stupefied. How could the minister possibly know the contents of the letter, which had never been out of his keeping for a single instant? Nevertheless, always master of himself, he held out the dispatch to the young king, Louis XIV, who took it with a blush. A solemn silence reigned in the cardinal's chamber. It was only troubled by the dull sound of the gold, which Mazarin, with his yellow, dry hand, piled up in a casket, whilst the king was reading.

‘And yet, Monsieur le Frondeur,’ said Mazarin, gayly, ‘the affair which you have taken in charge must, from the king—’

‘With which I have been given in charge, monseigneur. I do not run after affairs.’

‘Be it so. I say that this negotiation must pass through my hands. Let us lose no precious time, then. Tell me the conditions.’

‘I have had the honour of assuring your eminence that only the letter of his majesty King Charles II contains the revelation of his wishes.’

‘Pooh! you are ridiculous with your obstinacy, Monsieur Athos. It is plain you have kept company with the Puritans yonder. As to your secret, I know it better than you do; and you have done wrongly, perhaps, in not having shown some respect for a very old and suffering man, who has laboured much during his life, and kept the field for his ideas as bravely as you have for yours. You will not communicate your letter to me? You will say nothing to me? Very well! Come with me into my chamber; you shall speak to the king—and before the king.—Now, then, one last word: who gave you the Fleece? I remember you passed for having the Garter; but as to the Fleece, I do not know—’

‘Recently, my lord, Spain, on the occasion of the marriage of his majesty Louis XIV, sent King Charles II a *brevet* of the Fleece in blank; Charles II immediately transmitted it to me, filling up the blank with my name.’

Mazarin arose, and leaning on the arm of Bernouin, he returned to his ruelle at the moment the name of M. le Prince was being announced. The Prince de Condé, the first prince of the blood, the conqueror of Rocroi, Lens, and Nordlingen, was, in fact, entering the apartment of Monseigneur de Mazarin, followed by his gentlemen, and had already saluted the king, when the prime minister raised his curtain. Athos had time to see Raoul pressing the hand of the Comte de Guiche, and send him a smile in return for his respectful bow. He had time, likewise, to see the radiant countenance of the cardinal, when he perceived before him, upon the table, an enormous heap of gold, which the Comte de Guiche had won in a run of luck, after his eminence had confided his cards to him. So forgetting ambassador, embassy and prince, his first thought was of the gold. ‘What!’ cried the old man—‘all that—won?’

‘These are exactly the details I asked for,’ said the king. ‘Who and what are the two men of whom you speak?’

‘Two Frenchmen, sire.’

‘Indeed! I am glad of that.’

‘And the two ideas,’ said Mazarin;—‘I am more curious about ideas than about men, for my part.’

‘Yes,’ murmured the king.

‘The second idea, the devoted, reasonable idea—the least important, sir—was to go and dig up a million in gold, buried by King Charles I at Newcastle, and to purchase with that gold the adherence of Monk.’

‘Oh, oh!’ said Mazarin, reanimated by the word million. ‘But Newcastle was at the time occupied by Monk.’

‘Yes, monsieur le cardinal, and that is why I venture to call the idea courageous as well as devoted. It was necessary, if Monk refused the offers of the negotiator, to reinstate King Charles II in possession of this million, which was to be torn, as it were, from the loyalty and not the loyalism of General Monk. This was effected in spite of many difficulties: the general proved to be loyal, and allowed the money to be taken away.’

‘It seems to me,’ said the timid, thoughtful king, ‘that Charles II could not have known of this million whilst he was in Paris.’

‘It seems to me,’ rejoined the cardinal, maliciously, ‘that his majesty the king of Great Britain knew perfectly well of this million, but that he preferred having two millions to having one.’

‘Sire,’ said Athos, firmly, ‘the king of England, whilst in France, was so poor that he had not even money to take the post; so destitute of hope that he frequently thought of dying. He was so entirely ignorant of the existence of the million at Newcastle, that but for a gentleman—one of your majesty’s subjects—the moral depositary of the million, who revealed the secret to King Charles II, that prince would still be vegetating in the most cruel forgetfulness.’

‘Let us pass on to the strange, bold and ingenious idea,’ interrupted Mazarin, whose sagacity foresaw a check. ‘What was that idea?’

‘This—M. Monk formed the only obstacle to the re-establishment of the fallen king. A Frenchman imagined the idea of suppressing this obstacle.’

‘Oh! oh! but he is a scoundrel, that Frenchman,’ said Mazarin; ‘and the idea is not so ingenious as to prevent its author being tied up by the neck at the Place de Grève, by decree of the parliament.’

‘Your eminence is mistaken,’ replied Athos, dryly; ‘I did not say that the Frenchman in question had resolved to assassinate M. Monk, but only to suppress him. The words of the French language have a value which the gentlemen of France know perfectly. Besides, this is an affair of war; and when men serve kings against their enemies they are not to be condemned by a parliament—God is their judge. This French gentleman, then, formed the idea of gaining possession of the person of Monk, and he executed his plan.’

The king became animated at the recital of great actions. The king’s younger brother struck the table with his hand, exclaiming, ‘Ah! that is fine!’

‘He carried off Monk?’ said the king. ‘Why, Monk was in his camp.’

‘And the gentleman was alone, sire.’

‘That is marvellous!’ said Philip.

‘Marvellous, indeed!’ cried the king.

‘Good! There are the two little lions unchained,’ murmured the cardinal. And with an air of spice, which he did not dissemble: ‘I am unacquainted with these details, will you guarantee their authenticity, monsieur?’

‘All the more easily, my lord cardinal, from having seen the events.’

‘You have?’

‘Yes, monseigneur.’

The king had involuntarily drawn close to the count, the Duc d’Anjou had turned sharply round, and pressed Athos on the other side.

‘What next? monsieur, what next?’ cried they both at the same time.

‘Sire, M. Monk, being taken by the Frenchman, was brought to King Charles II, at the Hague. The king gave back his freedom to Monk, and the grateful general, in return, gave Charles II the throne of Great Britain, for which so many valiant men had fought in vain.’

Philip clapped his hands with enthusiasm, Louis XIV, more reflective, turned towards the Comte de la Fère.

‘Is this true,’ said he, ‘in all its details?’

‘Absolutely true, sire.’

d’affaires? You want nothing, monsieur, but the steel cap on your head, and a Bible at your girdle.’

‘Monsieur,’ said Athos, dryly, ‘I have never had, as you have, the advantage of treating with Cromwell; and I have only seen his charges d’affaires sword in hand; I am therefore ignorant of how he treated with prime ministers. As for the king of England, Charles II, I know that when he writes to his majesty King Louis XIV, he does not write to his eminence the Cardinal Mazarin. I see no diplomacy in that distinction.’

‘Ah!’ cried Mazarin, raising his attenuated hand, and striking his head, ‘I remember now!’ Athos looked at him in astonishment. ‘Yes, that is it!’ said the cardinal, continuing to look at his interlocutor; ‘yes, that is certainly it. I know you now, monsieur. Ah! diavolo! I am no longer astonished.’

‘In fact, I was astonished that, with your eminence’s excellent memory,’ replied Athos, smiling, ‘you had not recognized me before.’

‘Always refractory and grumbling—monsieur—monsieur—What do they call you? Stop—a name of a river—Potamos; no—the name of an island—Naxos; no, per Giove!—the name of a mountain—Athos! now I have it. Delighted to see you again, and to be no longer at Rueil, where you and your damned companions made me pay ransom. Fronde! still Fronde! accursed Fronde! Oh, what grudges! Why, monsieur, have your antipathies survived mine? If any one has cause to complain, I think it could not be you, who got out of the affair not only in a sound skin, but with the cordon of the Holy Ghost around your neck.’

‘My lord cardinal,’ replied Athos, ‘permit me not to enter into considerations of that kind. I have a mission to fulfil. Will you facilitate the means of my fulfilling that mission, or will you not?’

‘I am astonished,’ said Mazarin,—quite delighted at having recovered his memory, and bristling with malice,—‘I am astonished, Monsieur—Athos—that a Frondeur like you should have accepted a mission for the Perfidious Mazarin, as used to be said in the good old times—’ And Mazarin began to laugh, in spite of a painful cough, which cut short his sentences, converting them into sobs.

‘I have only accepted the mission near the king of France, monsieur le cardinal,’ retorted the comte, though with less asperity, for he thought he had sufficiently the advantage to show himself moderate.

'It is remarkable that the king of England should choose a Frenchman for his ambassador; it is an excellent augury. Your name, monsieur, if you please.'

'Comte de la Fère,' replied Athos, bowing more slightly than the ceremonial and pride of the all-powerful minister required.

Mazarin bent his shoulders, as if to say:—

'I do not know that name.'

Athos did not alter his carriage.

'And you come, monsieur,' continued Mazarin, 'to tell me—'

'I come on the part of his majesty the king of Great Britain to announce to the king of France'—Mazarin frowned—'to announce to the king of France,' continued Athos, imperturbably, 'the happy restoration of his majesty Charles II to the throne of his ancestors.'

This shade did not escape his cunning eminence. Mazarin was too much accustomed to mankind, not to see in the cold and almost haughty politeness of Athos, an index of hostility, which was not of the temperate of that hot-house called a court.

'You have powers, I suppose?' asked Mazarin, in a short, querulous tone.

'Yes, monseigneur.' And the word 'monseigneur' came so painfully from the lips of Athos that it might be said it skinned them.

Athos took from an embroidered velvet bag which he carried under his doublet a dispatch. The cardinal held out his hand for it. 'Your pardon, monseigneur,' said Athos. 'My dispatch is for the king.'

'Since you are a Frenchman, monsieur, you ought to know the position of a prime minister at the court of France.'

'There was a time,' replied Athos, 'when I occupied myself with the importance of prime ministers; but I have formed, long ago, a resolution to treat no longer with any but the king.'

'Then, monsieur,' said Mazarin, who began to be irritated, 'you will neither see the minister nor the king.'

Mazarin rose. Athos replaced his dispatch in its bag, bowed gravely, and made several steps towards the door. This coolness exasperated Mazarin. 'What strange diplomatic proceedings are these!' cried he. 'Have we returned to the times when Cromwell sent us bulles in the guise of chargés

'That one of my gentlemen knew the secret of the milllion, and kept it?'

'Yes, sire.'

'The name of that gentleman?'

'It was your humble servant,' said Athos, simply, and bowing.

A murmur of admiration made the heart of Athos swell with pleasure. He had reason to be proud, at least. Mazarin, himself, had raised his arms towards heaven.

'Monsieur,' said the king, 'I shall seek and find means to reward you.'

Athos made a movement. 'Oh, not for your honesty, to be paid for that would humiliate you; but I owe you a reward for having participated in the restoration of my brother, King Charles II.'

'Certainly,' said Mazarin.

'It is the triumph of a good cause which fills the whole house of France with joy,' said Anne of Austria.

'I continue,' said Louis XIV: 'Is it also true that a single man penetrated to Monk, in his camp, and carried him off?'

'That man had ten auxiliaries, taken from a very inferior rank.'

'And nothing more but them?'

'Nothing more.'

'And he is named?'

'Monsieur d'Artragnan, formerly lieutenant of the musketeers of your majesty.'

Anne of Austria coloured; Mazarin became yellow with shame; Louis XIV was deeply thoughtful, and a drop of moisture fell from his pale brow. 'What men!' murmured he. And, involuntarily, he darted a glance at the minister which would have terrified him, if Mazarin, at the moment, had not concealed his head under his pillow.

'Monsieur,' said the young Duc d'Anjou, placing his hand, delicate and white as that of a woman, upon the arm of Athos, 'tell that brave man, I beg you, that Monsieur, brother of the king, will to-morrow drink his health before five hundred of the best gentlemen of France.' And, on finishing those words, the young man, perceiving that his enthusiasm had deranged one of his ruffles, set to work to put it to rights with the greatest care imaginable.

‘Let us resume business, sire,’ interrupted Mazarin, who never was enthusiastic, and who wore no ruffles.

‘Yes, monsieur,’ replied Louis XIV. ‘Pursue your communication, monsieur le comte,’ added he, turning towards Athos.

Athos immediately began and offered in due form the hand of the Princess Henrietta Stuart to the young prince, the king’s brother. The conference lasted an hour; after which the doors of the chamber were thrown open to the courtiers, who resumed their places as if nothing had been kept from them in the occupations of that evening. Athos then found himself again with Raoul, and the father and son were able to clasp each other’s hands.

Chapter XI

An Affair of State



HE cardinal, on passing into his cabinet, found the Comte de la Fère, who was waiting for him, engaged in admiring a very fine Raphael placed over a sideboard covered with a plate. His eminence came in softly, lightly, and as silently as a shadow, and surprised the countenance of the comte, as he was accustomed to do, pretending to divine by the simple expression of the face of his interlocutor what would be the result of the conversation.

But this time Mazarin was foiled in his expectation: he read nothing upon the face of Athos, not even the respect he was accustomed to see on all faces. Athos was dressed in black, with a simple lacing of silver. He wore the Holy Ghost, the Garter, and the Golden Fleece, three orders of such importance, that a king alone, or else a player, could wear them at once.

Mazarin rummaged a long time in his somewhat troubled memory to recall the name he ought to give to this icy figure, but he did not succeed. ‘I am told,’ said he, at length, ‘you have a message from England for me.’

And he sat down, dismissing Bernouin, who, in his quality of secretary, was getting his pen ready.

‘On the part of his majesty, the king of England, yes, your eminence.’

‘You speak very good French for an Englishman, monsieur,’ said Mazarin, graciously, looking through his fingers at the Holy Ghost, Garter, and Golden Fleece, but more particularly at the face of the messenger.

‘I am not an Englishman, but a Frenchman, monsieur le cardinal,’ replied Athos.

Chapter XLII

In Which Mazarin Becomes Prodigal



HUST Mazarin was endeavouring to recover from the serious alarm he had just experienced, Athos and Raoul were exchanging a few words in a corner of the apartment.

‘Well, here you are at Paris, then, Raoul?’ said the comte.

‘Yes, monsieur, since the return of M. le Prince.’

‘I cannot converse freely with you here, because we are observed; but I shall return home presently, and shall expect you as soon as your duty permits.’

Raoul bowed, and, at that moment, M. le Prince came up to them. The prince had that clear and keen look which distinguishes birds of prey of the noble species; his physiognomy itself presented several distinct traits of this resemblance. It is known that in the Prince de Condé, the aquiline nose rose out sharply and incisively from a brow slightly retreating, rather low than high, and according to the railers of the court,—a pitiless race without mercy even for genius,—constituted rather an eagle’s beak than a human nose, in the heir of the illustrious princes of the house of Condé. This penetrating look, this imperious expression of the whole countenance, generally disturbed those to whom the prince spoke, more than either majesty or regular beauty could have done in the conqueror of Rocroi. Besides this, the fire mounted so suddenly to his projecting eyes, that with the prince every sort of animation resembled passion. Now, on account of his rank, everybody at the court respected M. le Prince, and many even, seeing only the man, carried their respect as far as terror.

Louis de Condé then advanced towards the Comte de la Fère and Raoul, with the marked intention of being saluted by the one, and of speaking with the other. No man bowed with more reserved grace than the Comte de la Fère. He disdained to put into a salutation all the shades which a courtier ordinarily borrows from the same colour—the desire to please. Athos knew his own personal value, and bowed to the prince like a man, correcting by something sympathetic and undefinable that which might have appeared offensive to the pride of the highest rank in the inflexibility of his attitude. The prince was about to speak to Raoul. Athos forestalled him. ‘If M. le Vicomte de Bragelonne,’ said he, ‘were not one of the humble servants of your royal highness, I would beg him to pronounce my name before you—mon prince.’

‘I have the honour to address Monsieur le Comte de la Fère,’ said Condé, instantly.

‘My protector,’ added Raoul, blushing.

‘One of the most honourable men in the kingdom,’ continued the prince; ‘one of the first gentlemen of France, and of whom I have heard so much that I have frequently desired to number him among my friends.’

‘An honour of which I should be unworthy,’ replied Athos, ‘but for the respect and admiration I entertain for your royal highness.’

‘Monsieur de Bragelonne,’ said the prince, ‘is a good officer, and it is plainly seen that he has been to a good school. Ah, monsieur le comte, in your time, generals had soldiers!’

‘That is true, my lord, but nowadays soldiers have generals.’

This compliment, which savoured so little of flattery, gave a thrill of joy to the man whom already Europe considered a hero; and who might be thought to be satiated with praise.

‘I regret very much,’ continued the prince, ‘that you should have retired from the service, monsieur le comte; for it is more than probable that the king will soon have a war with Holland or England, and opportunities for distinguishing himself would not be wanting for a man who, like you, knows Great Britain as well as you do France.’

‘I believe I may say, monseigneur, that I have acted wisely in retiring from the service,’ said Athos, smiling. ‘France and Great Britain will henceforward live like two sisters, if I can trust my presentiments.’

‘Your presentiments?’

At the same time he turned round in his ruelle, the curtains of which, in falling, concealed the bed. The cardinal, nevertheless, did not lose sight of the conspirators.

‘M. le Comte de Guiche,’ said he, in a fretful voice, whilst putting on, behind the curtain, his dressing-gown, with the assistance of Bernouin.

‘I am here, my lord,’ said the young man, as he approached.

‘Take my cards, you are lucky. Win a little money for me of these gentlemen.’

‘Yes, my lord.’

The young man sat down at the table from which the king withdrew to talk with the two queens. A serious game was commenced between the comte and several rich courtiers. In the meantime Philip was discussing the questions of dress with the Chevalier de Lorraine, and they had ceased to hear the rustling of the cardinal's silk robe from behind the curtain. His eminence had followed Bernouin into the closet adjoining the bedroom.